User Research & Accessibility Audit

A student-centered review of Google Classroom

Prepared by	Shiban Partho Nandi
Selected product	Google Classroom
Target audience	College students using Classroom for everyday academic work
Research method	Documented heuristic review + accessibility evidence review
Task objective	Turn student-use observations into a clear design problem and measurable success criteria

1. Product & Target User

Google Classroom is a learning platform used by schools and colleges to distribute classwork, communicate with students, collect submissions, and return feedback. Students can use it on the web and through mobile apps.

Target user

Primary persona: A college student who manages several subjects through Google Classroom. The student checks announcements, finds upcoming work, opens learning material, submits assignments, and returns later to check grades or feedback.

AREA	USER CONTEXT
Needs	Quick access to upcoming work, clear instructions, easy submission, visible feedback, low cognitive load.
Typical context	Laptop or Android phone; often switching between multiple subjects and other study tools.
Common pressure	Deadlines, many classes, notifications, attachments, and different teacher posting styles.
Accessibility needs	Readable text, understandable structure, keyboard/screen-reader support, clear controls and predictable navigation.

Key student journeys reviewed

- Find work: open Classroom → choose a class → locate upcoming or missing work.
- Understand work: open Classwork → select an assignment → read instructions and attachments.
- Submit work: attach/open the required file → submit → confirm the status.
- Check progress: review returned work, marks, feedback, and due dates.
- Stay informed: manage class and device notifications without being overwhelmed.

Google's current student guidance confirms these core flows, including the Due soon area, Classwork organization, assignment submission, feedback/grades, and notification controls.

2. Research Method

Because this internship task permits a documented heuristic review, the study was structured around realistic student tasks rather than fabricated interview responses.

Audit procedure

STEP	ACTIVITY	WHAT WAS REVIEWED
01	Define the user	College student managing multiple classes and deadlines.
02	Map key tasks	Find work, understand instructions, submit, check feedback, manage notifications.
03	Review usability	Look for clarity, consistency, discoverability, feedback, and unnecessary effort.
04	Review accessibility	Check navigation, readability, contrast, forms/controls, and mobile use.
05	Record evidence	Link observations to official Google Classroom documentation where relevant.
06	Prioritize	Rate each opportunity as High, Medium, or Low impact.

Evaluation criteria

AREA	QUESTION
Navigation	Can a student understand where to go next without guessing?
Readability	Can important information be scanned quickly, especially around deadlines?
Contrast & visual hierarchy	Do headings, labels, status information and actions remain easy to distinguish?
Forms & controls	Are actions, attachments, submission states and settings understandable?
Mobile usability	Can the same essential student tasks be completed comfortably on a phone?
Accessibility	Are assistive technologies and keyboard-oriented workflows supported and discoverable?

3. Research Findings & Pain Points

The strongest design opportunities are not about adding more features. They are about helping students understand what needs attention, what happens next, and whether an action was completed successfully.

#	FINDING	OBSERVATION	IMPACT
1	Deadline visibility	Students often manage several classes at once. A clear cross-class view of upcoming, missing and completed work reduces the need to open every class separately.	High
2	Classwork scanning	Topic-based organization is useful, but long classwork pages can still require scanning and expanding sections to find one specific item.	Medium
3	Submission confidence	Submitting an attachment is a high-stakes action for a student. The interface should make the final state unmistakable and reduce uncertainty about whether work was actually handed in.	High
4	Notification control	Notifications are valuable for deadlines and returned work, but too many signals can become distracting. Students need simple control over what matters most.	Medium
5	Accessibility discoverability	Classroom supports screen readers and keyboard-oriented workflows, but accessibility features may not be obvious to a student who has never looked for them.	Medium
6	Mobile context	Mobile support is strong for core tasks, but students may have less screen space when reading long instructions, attachments or multiple class updates.	Medium

What works well

- The student homepage brings upcoming work and active classes into one place.
- Classwork can be organized by topics and students can collapse/expand topic groups.
- Students can check feedback and grades after work is returned.

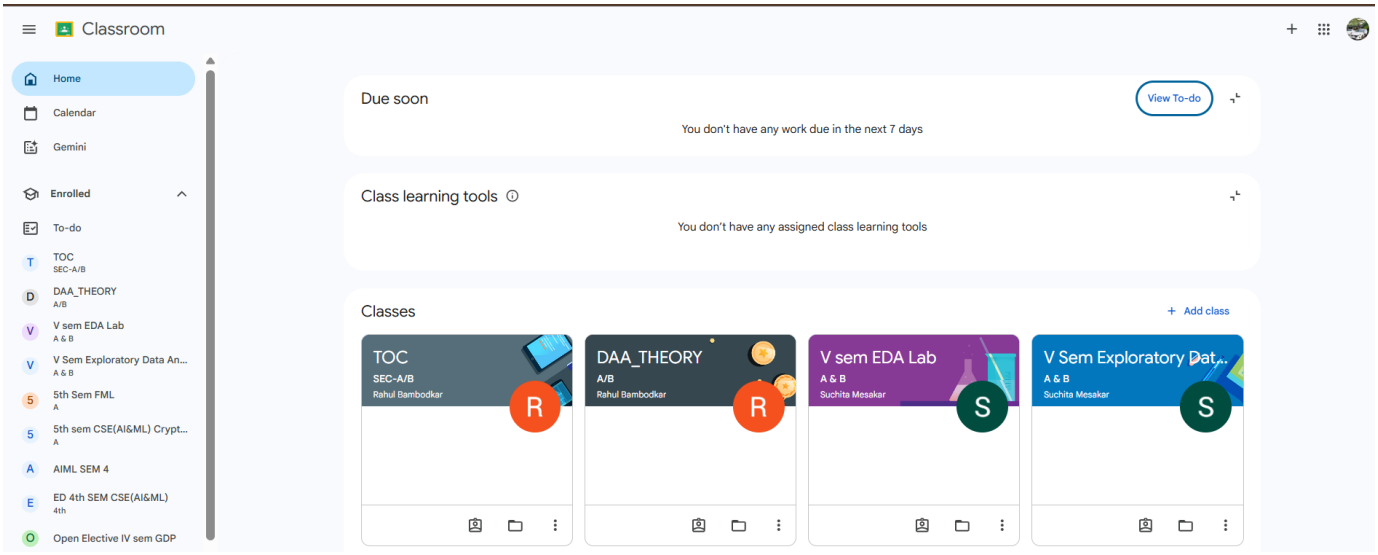
4. Accessibility Audit

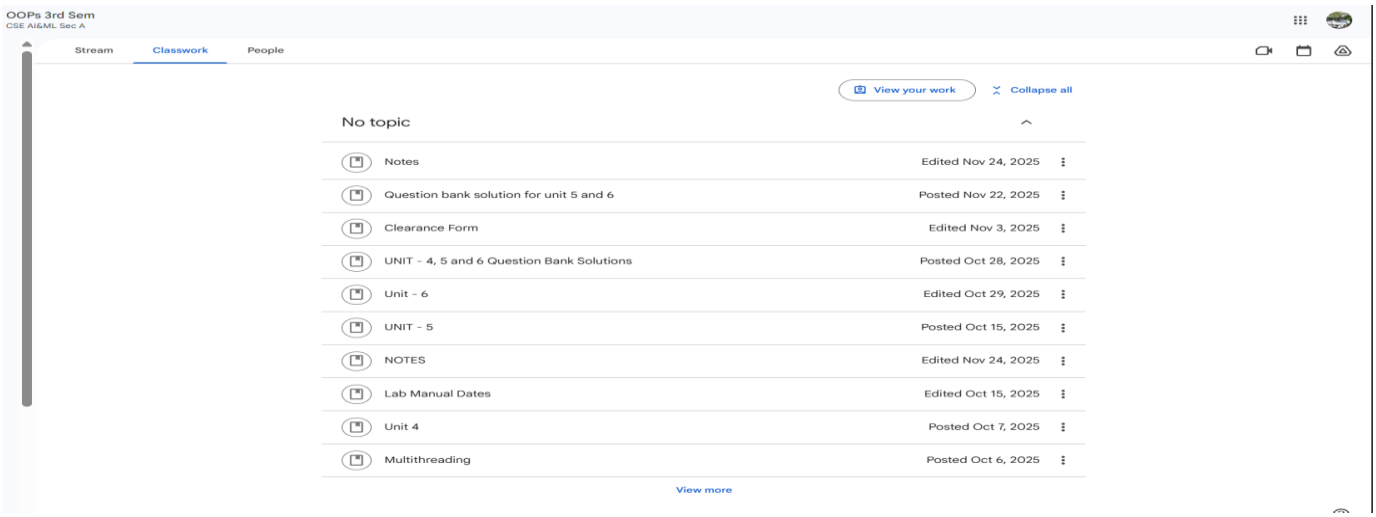
The audit focuses on the areas explicitly required by the internship brief. Ratings describe the design opportunity observed/researched, not a claim that Google Classroom fails a formal accessibility standard.

AREA	OBSERVATION	IMPACT	RECOMMENDATION
Navigation	The product has clear primary areas such as Home, Stream, Classwork and People. The student homepage also surfaces upcoming work.	Low–Medium	Keep primary destinations stable and make the 'next action' obvious when a student enters a class.
Readability	Classwork can contain many posts, topics and attachments. Topic grouping and collapse/expand controls help scanning.	Medium	Use concise topic names and keep important deadline/status information visually prominent.
Contrast	Core interface uses strong text hierarchy and familiar Google-style controls. Individual teacher-created materials can vary in visual quality.	Medium	Encourage accessible content practices for teacher-created materials, especially text contrast and meaningful headings.
Forms / controls	Assignment submission, attachment actions and notification settings are task-critical controls.	Medium	Use clear labels, predictable states and explicit confirmation after important actions.
Mobile usability	The mobile app supports viewing	Medium	Prioritize short paths for urgent actions and keep

	work, submitting assignments, checking feedback/marks and some offline actions.		long instructions/attachments easy to scan.
Assistive technology	Google documents support for screen readers on desktop and mobile, including navigation and common student tasks.	Low–Medium	Make accessibility support easier to discover and preserve semantic labels/keyboard order.

Evidence screenshot





5. Design Problem & Success Criteria

Design problem statement

Students use Google Classroom to manage multiple subjects, deadlines and submissions, but the experience can still require unnecessary scanning and interpretation—especially when several classes have active work at the same time. The design opportunity is to make priority, status and next steps easier to understand at a glance without adding complexity.

How might we…

How might we help students quickly identify what needs attention, understand the status of their work, and complete important actions confidently across desktop and mobile?

Measurable success criteria

#	CRITERION	MEASURABLE TARGET
01	Priority	A student should identify their next 3 urgent academic actions within 20 seconds from the home/to-do experience.
02	Findability	A student should locate a specific assignment within 30 seconds without opening unrelated class sections.
03	Submission confidence	After submission, the student should be able to identify the current submission state in under 5 seconds.
04	Accessibility	All critical student actions should remain understandable when using keyboard navigation and a supported screen reader.
05	Mobile	A student should be able to find, open and submit a typical assignment on a phone without horizontal scrolling or hidden primary actions.

Design direction

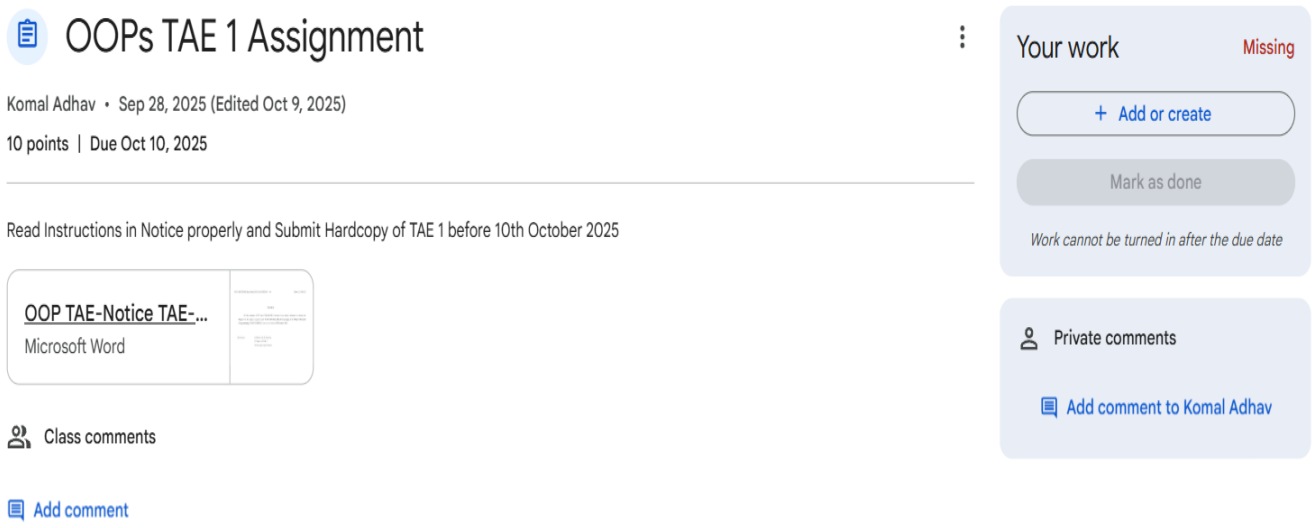
The strongest direction is a lightweight student priority layer: make urgency, submission state and feedback more visible while preserving the familiar Classroom structure. This is an opportunity for clearer hierarchy—not a complete redesign.

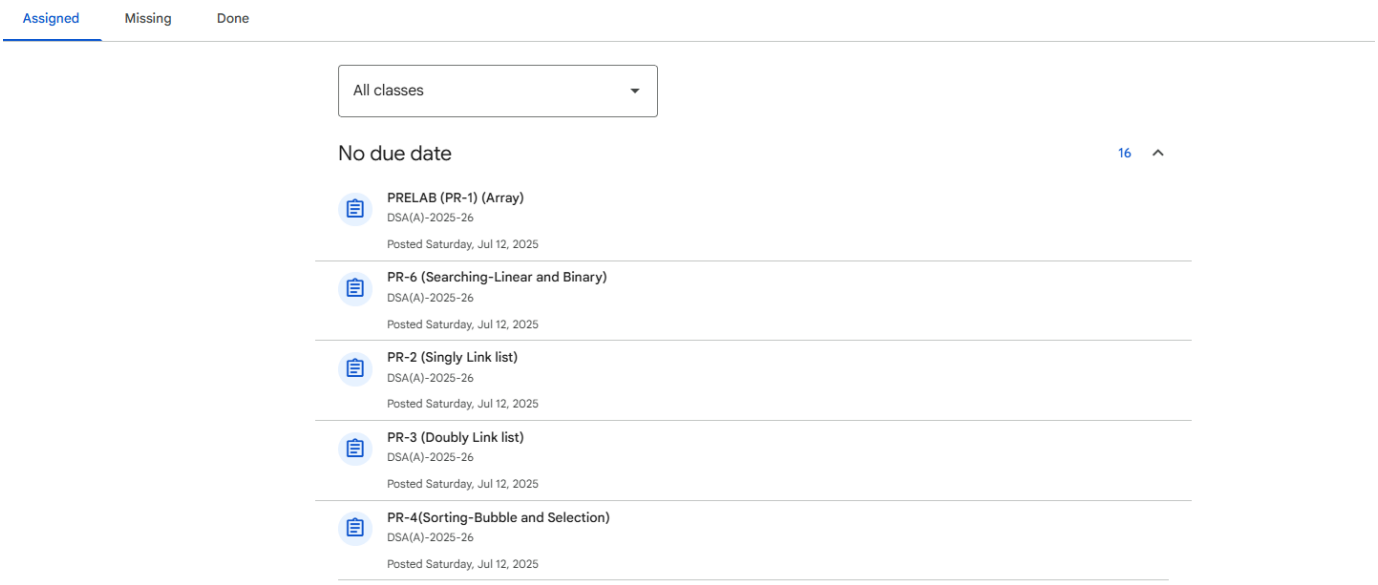
6. Evidence Log & Research Limitations

Evidence log

ID	EVIDENCE	WHAT IT SUPPORTS	SOURCE
E1	Student homepage	Google states that the homepage surfaces upcoming assignments through the Due soon module and provides access to active classes.	Official Google Classroom student guide
E2	Classwork organization	Google documents that students can arrange work by topic and collapse/expand topic sections.	Official Google Classroom Classwork guide
E3	Feedback & grades	Students can check marks and feedback after work is returned.	Official Google Classroom student/mobile guide
E4	Notifications	Students can customize email and device notifications, including assignment and returned-work updates.	Official Google Classroom notification guide
E5	Accessibility	Google documents screen-reader support for students and recommended browser/screen-reader combinations.	Official Google Classroom accessibility guide

Research evidence screenshots





Limitations & next step

- This submission uses a documented heuristic review because no participant responses were supplied for this report.
- A future round should validate the highest-impact findings with at least 3 real student participants.
- Screenshots from the researcher's own Classroom account should be added to the final evidence folder if EdVyro expects visual proof of observations.
- A formal WCAG conformance audit would require additional technical testing and should not be inferred from this UX review alone.

This keeps the report evidence-based without inventing users, quotes, or test results.

7. Conclusion

Google Classroom already provides a strong foundation for student learning workflows: students can see upcoming work, organize classwork, submit assignments, receive feedback, manage notifications, and use accessibility support.

The clearest UX opportunity is reducing uncertainty. Students should not have to wonder what is urgent, whether an assignment was submitted, or where to find feedback. A small improvement in visual hierarchy and status communication could make the experience feel calmer and more predictable—especially for students managing several subjects.

Recommended priority

1. Improve priority/status visibility → 2. Strengthen submission confirmation → 3. Simplify scanning on mobile → 4. Make accessibility support more discoverable.

Sources

- 1. Google Classroom — About Classroom: https://support.google.com/edu/classroom/answer/6020279
- 2. Google Classroom — Get started with Classroom for students: https://support.google.com/edu/classroom/answer/9582544
- 3. Google Classroom — Find your Classwork: https://support.google.com/edu/classroom/answer/6020284
- 4. Google Classroom — Screen reader support for students: https://support.google.com/edu/classroom/answer/6084551
- 5. Google Classroom — Manage notifications: https://support.google.com/edu/classroom/answer/6141557
- 6. Google Classroom — Use Classroom offline: https://support.google.com/edu/classroom/answer/11015503